

practices contribute to the number of personal bankruptcies, to marital instability, to the loss of jobs, and to invasions of individual privacy.”

Don't talk;  
they'll use it  
against you.

True, and the intentions of the act were good, but “deceptive, unfair, or abusive” is in the eye of the beholder. Yelling at you, swearing at you, and telephone harassment have been determined to be “abusive,” but there is still a lot of gray area. Debt collectors push. You can push back.

Pardon my course language, but you don't have to take their crap. Now that you know the basic ground rules, you are better equipped to deal with the obnoxious debt collectors who left their hearts, and their manners, somewhere else when they left for work.

The most important lesson for you to remember is that you do not have to talk to a debt collector until you are ready to face them, armed with knowledge. It is as easy as hanging up the phone. You do not have to return their calls. Until you are ready, do not talk to them. They want you to think that they have a crystal ball and know your every move. They don't. Don't give them any information. Remember, and review, the *Debt Cures* methods detailed previously in Chapter 4 where I talked about how you can eliminate your debt!

## Unfair Practices

These collectors are trained to be aggressive and are trained to lie. They operate in a boiler room with a competitive tally board posted to show who had the most kills, or collections. They get an adrenaline rush from sticking it to you. One power-charged collector stated in the movie *Maxed Out* that “it feels great.” He likened the high he got to “throwing a touchdown pass and getting paid for it.” He was making a nice living, paying his bills by preying on people who were having trouble paying theirs. He called the underworld of collections a “fun industry. It's competitive and you get your paycheck.” The daily scoreboard was a great motivator for him to harass people like you.

Some employees of the collection agencies go the opposite direction, or so it may seem. They are taught to operate on your emotions and